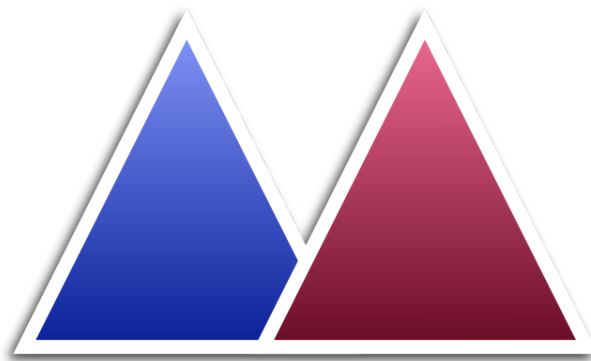




MAJU

Work in Progress: Expanding Co-working Spaces

Providing free, conducive co-working spaces at void decks and community centres

By: National Development Policy Centre, MAJU

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ABOUT MAJU

This policy paper summary was written by members of MAJU. MAJU is an independent, youth-led organisation that focuses on engaging Singaporean youths in a long-term research process to guide them in jointly formulating policy ideas of their own.

By sharing our unique youth perspectives, MAJU hopes to contribute to the policymaking discourse and future of Singapore.

1. INTRODUCTION	3
1.1 THE TREND TOWARDS HYBRID WORK	3
1.2 RECEPTION OF HYBRID WORKING MODELS	4
1.3 PROS AND CONS OF HYBRID WORK	4
1.3.a Pro: Flexibility to Manage Other Commitments	4
1.3.b Con: No Work-life Separation	5
1.3.c Con: Increased Family Tension	5
1.3.d Pro: Improved Productivity and Creativity	5
1.3.e Con: Decreased Productivity	6
1.3.f Pro: Reduced Travel and Carbon Footprint	6
1.3.g Pro: Better Diversity and Inclusion	6
1.4 SUMMARY	6
2. CURRENT MEASURES	7
2.1 LIST OF CURRENT MEASURES	7
2.1.a Personal and Community Spaces	7
2.1.b Commercial Spaces	8
2.1.c Other Government Spaces	9
2.2 USER CONSIDERATIONS FOR CO-WORKING SPACES	10
2.2.a Privacy	10
2.2.b Accessibility	10
2.2.c Wi-Fi and Charging	10
2.2.e Capacity Preview	10
2.2.f Amenities	11
2.2.g Price	11
2.3 EVALUATION OF CURRENT MEASURES	12
2.3.a Current Measures Comparison Table	12
2.3.b Evaluation	13
3. PROBLEM STATEMENT	14
3.1 OVERVIEW OF SITUATION	14
3.2 PROBLEM STATEMENT	14
3.3 DIFFERENCES WITH GOVERNMENT APPROACH	14
3.3.a Public Service Co-Working Network	14
3.3.b Boon Lay Void Deck Study Pods	15
3.3.c Marsiling MRT Co-working Space	15
3.3.d Evaluation	15
4. PROPOSED SOLUTION	16
4.1 PROVISION OF ACCESSIBLE CO-WORKING SPACES	16
4.1.a Selected Pathways	16
4.1.b Rationale for Chosen Pathways	16
4.2 OVERVIEW OF TWIN MODALITIES	17

4.2.a Void Deck Modality	17
4.2.b Community Centre Modality	18
4.3 GOVERNMENT CONSIDERATIONS	19
4.3.a Overarching Models of Co-Working Spaces	20
4.3.b Scalability	20
4.3.c Cost	20
4.3.d Administrating Party	20
4.3.e Competing Use of Community Space	20
4.3.f Agglomeration and Social Benefits	20
4.4 COMPARISON OF TWIN MODALITIES	21
4.4.a Twin Modalities Comparison Table	21
Overarching Model	21
4.4.b Evaluation	22
4.5 MODALITY-SPECIFIC CONSIDERATIONS	23
4.5.a Void Deck - Noise Levels	23
4.5.b Void Deck - Non-Work Users	23
4.5.c CCs - Overcompetition and Equality of Access	23
4.6 MITIGATING COSTS	23
4.6.a Complementary Credits	23
4.6.b Income-based Subsidies	23
4.6.c Needs-based Subsidies	23
5. FURTHER EXPANSION	24
5.1 DEVELOPING A CO-WORKING ECOSYSTEM	24
5.2 EXPANSION TO RCs AND RNs	24
5.3 TARGETED RESOURCE ALLOCATION	24
5.4 FEEDBACK GATHERING MECHANISMS	24
5.5 COORDINATING PUBLIC COMMUNICATIONS	24
6. CONCLUSION	25
7. APPENDIX	26
APPENDIX A - DEMOGRAPHIC DATA OF RESPONDENTS	26
APPENDIX B - REFERENCES	26

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 THE TREND TOWARDS HYBRID WORK

Social distancing efforts prompted by COVID-19 have accelerated the trend towards hybrid work, where workers alternate between different working environments, such as from home and in an office.¹ In line with this, more employers are recognising the benefits of hybrid work and incorporating them (elaborated in Section 1.4). Furthermore, a study in 2022 found that two in five workers in Singapore would not take a job that does not offer hybrid work.²

1.2 RECEPTION OF HYBRID WORKING MODELS

The reception for hybrid work arrangements amongst workers has been generally positive. A survey by Randstad found that 41% of workers preferred working remotely over receiving a bigger bonus, and 77% felt that flexibility of work location is vital.³ However, 36% of Singaporeans felt the home was a difficult place to work and 35% felt more burned out by work when working at home.⁴ Another survey found that “[w]orking from home has imbued in employees an ‘always on’ mindset and many are working beyond standard hours.”⁵ While many workers claim to prefer hybrid work, actual conditions vary from worker to worker. The prevalence of hybrid work also varies significantly across industries.⁶ In industries such as finance, take-up is very high. Contrarily, industries like retail and F&B, and professions which handle sensitive information, are unlikely to adopt it. Nonetheless, given increasing popularity, a survey found that 58% of 150 firms in the Asia-Pacific expressed intentions to retain hybrid work.⁷ The government has also been advocating flexible work arrangements.⁸

¹ “Hybrid Working Definition and Meaning: Collins English Dictionary,” Hybrid working definition and meaning | Collins English Dictionary (HarperCollins Publishers Ltd), accessed January 17, 2023, <https://www.collinsdictionary.com/dictionary/english/hybrid-working>.

² Yun Ting Choo, “2 In 5 Workers in Singapore Would Not Accept a Job If They Cannot Work from Home: Study,” The Straits Times (The Straits Times, August 15, 2022), <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/jobs/2-in-5-workers-in-singapore-would-not-accept-a-job-if-they-cannot-work-from-home-study>.

³ “Singapore Employees Rather Be Jobless than Feel Unhappy at Work,” 41% of Singaporeans Would Rather Be Unemployed Than Feel Unhappy In Their Jobs | Randstad Singapore (randstad, August 15, 2022), <https://www.randstad.com.sg/hr-trends/workforce-trends/singapore-employees-rather-be-jobless-than-feel-unhappy-at-work/>.

⁴ Ipsos, “Return to the Workplace 2021 Global Survey - Ipsos,” RETURN TO THE WORKPLACE 2021 GLOBAL SURVEY (Ipsos, 2021), <https://www.ipsos.com/sites/default/files/ct/news/documents/2021-07/Global%20Advisor%20-%20Return%20to%20Workplace%20Survey.pdf>.

⁵ “Ups-and-Downs When It Comes to Work-Life Balance for Singaporeans: Workmonitor Survey,” The Ups and Downs of Work-Life Balance in Singapore | Randstad Singapore, April 6, 2022, <https://www.randstad.com.sg/hr-trends/workforce-trends/ups-and-downs-of-work-life-balance-in-singapore/>.

⁶ “Are Singaporeans Working More Remotely?,” Article: Impact of COVID-19: Remote Working in Singapore, accessed January 17, 2023, <https://stats.mom.gov.sg/Pages/Impact-of-COVID-19-Remote-Working-in-Singapore.aspx>.

⁷ CBRE RESEARCH, “Spring 2022 Asia Pacific Survey” (Crafting the Post-Pandemic Office, May 2022), <https://www.cbre.com/-/media/project/cbre/shared-site/insights/reports/asia-pacific-occupier-survey-spring-2022/asia-pacific-occupier-survey-2022-v2.pdf>.

⁸ Ministry of Manpower, “Tripartite Statement on Flexible Work Arrangements,” Ministry of Manpower Singapore (Ministry of Manpower Singapore, April 22, 2022), <https://www.mom.gov.sg/newsroom/press-replies/2022/0422-tripartite-statement-on-flexible-work-arrangements#:~:text=The%20Tripartite%20Standard%20on%20Flexible,by%20the%20end%20of%202022.>

1.3 PROS AND CONS OF HYBRID WORK

As this paper proposes the provision of free, non-home co-working spaces to accommodate the increased demand (further elaborated in Chapter 4), we will briefly evaluate the advantages and disadvantages of hybrid work.

1.3.a Pro: Flexibility to Manage Other Commitments

Many workers have care obligations on top of work. In particular, the ‘sandwiched generation’, which the Ministry of Social and Family Development terms as the “layer of people who are caring for both children and parents at the same time”, are especially affected. Work from Home (WFH) allows parents to be gainfully employed while flexibly managing care obligations.

1.3.b Con: No Work-life Separation

Notwithstanding these advantages, WFH blurs the boundaries between work and home. According to TODAY, working from home overexerts employees as their work-life balance is disrupted⁹. Colleagues assume that they are always available to do work. This could eventually lead to burnout, increased absenteeism, lower productivity, and even mental health issues, where employees are susceptible to greater emotional exhaustion and cognitive stress.¹⁰ However, some studies support the positive impact of WFH on work-life balance as workers have more flexibility to adjust their schedule around family commitments.¹¹ The effects of WFH on work-life balance thus depends, perhaps on factors like geography or nature of work.

1.3.c Con: Increased Family Tension

Some studies highlight the link between WFH and increased family tensions. With WFH, parents are expected to perform roles both as an employee and parent concurrently. Homes double up as spaces of work and learning. The added stress of fulfilling multiple roles in the workplace and home environment could lead to increased tensions. For instance, 54% of parents working from home state that their work has caused arguments with their children.¹²

1.3.d Pro: Improved Productivity and Creativity

The implementation of hybrid work could also enhance the productivity of workers as they can select a conducive work environment for themselves e.g. public workspaces, which might

⁹ Natasha Meah, “The Big Read: Working from Home Becomes a Nightmare When Lines Are Blurred and Boundaries Trampled,” TODAY (today, October 17, 2020), <https://www.todayonline.com/big-read/big-read-working-home-becomes-nightmare-when-lines-are-blurred-and-boundaries-trampled>.

¹⁰ Jodi Oakman et al., “A Rapid Review of Mental and Physical Health Effects of Working at Home: How Do We Optimise Health?,” *BMC Public Health* 20, no. 1 (2020), <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-020-09875-z>.

¹¹ Pradit Songsangyos and Supakorn Iamamporn, “Remote Working with Work-Life Balance,” *International Journal of Applied Computer Technology and Information Systems* 9, no. 2 (October 2019), <http://203.158.98.12/actisjournal/index.php/IJACTIS/article/view/337/280>.

¹² Jim Wilson, “Parents Working from Home See Negative Effects on Family Relations, Wellbeing: Report,” Canadian HR Reporter (Canadian HR Reporter, January 14, 2020), <https://www.hrreporter.com/news/hr-news/parents-working-from-home-see-negative-effects-on-family-relations-wellbeing-report/324921>.

justify setting up more co-working spaces. Beyond this, remote work could also spark better creativity,¹³ although it could also result in less collaborativeness.¹⁴

1.3.e Con: Decreased Productivity

Individual performance and team-level performance may deteriorate when employees work from home.¹⁵ This could be due to increased distraction or employees being unproductive due to lack of supervision. The absence of physical interaction may also lead to less feedback and informal learning. Furthermore, Singapore's high population density might present noise nuisances which makes households uncondusive for remote working.

1.3.f Pro: Reduced Travel and Carbon Footprint

Without the need to commute to the office arising from hybrid work arrangements — on which our proposal is premised — travel time could be used elsewhere. Additionally, less traffic would reduce congestion and carbon footprint, in alignment with the Singapore Green Plan 2030. Reduced congestion would also have second-order boosts on productivity.

1.3.g Pro: Better Diversity and Inclusion

Fixed working hours and the need to commute are barriers to some workers e.g. Persons with Disabilities. Hybrid work breaks these barriers down, increasing access to opportunities. The working population could then become more diverse and inclusive. In addition, public co-working spaces can foster the exchange of ideas of workers across different industries, potentially resulting in second-order boosts on productivity.¹⁶

1.3.h Con: Growing Socioeconomic Inequality

Shifting the workplace into homes gives employees with more conducive home environments an advantage. Downstream effects of this gap in working conditions could include reduced productivity, opportunities for progression, and even widening SES gaps.

1.4 SUMMARY

Cognisant of the trend towards hybrid work and the complex reality of hybrid work arrangements, this policy proposal seeks to further augment the benefits of hybrid work (productivity, work-life balance etc.) while mitigating the detriments. It is still too early to determine the long-term effects, good or bad, of hybrid work. However, given its early promise, this policy proposal seeks to expand access to conducive hybrid work spaces by addressing the issue of homes being uncondusive for hybrid work.

¹³ Leigh L. Thompson and Elizabeth Ruth Wilson, "Creativity in Teams," *Emerging Trends in the Social and Behavioral Sciences*, 2015, pp. 1-14, <https://doi.org/10.1002/9781118900772.etrds0056>.

¹⁴ David Holtz, "The Effects of Remote Work on Collaboration among Information Workers," *MIT Initiative On The Digital Economy* 5 (December 2022), <https://doi.org/10.1530/ey.19.15.13>.

¹⁵ Tanja Lippe and Zoltán Lippényi, "Co-Workers Working from Home and Individual and Team Performance," *New Technology, Work and Employment* 35, no. 1 (2019): pp. 60-79, <https://doi.org/10.1111/ntwe.12153>.

¹⁶ Krist Boo, "S'pore Co-Sharing Spaces Set to Grow as WeWork Launches Largest Such Facility Here," *The Straits Times*, September 9, 2022, <https://www.straitstimes.com/business/companies-markets/spore-co-sharing-spaces-set-to-grow-as-wework-launches-largest-such-facility-here>.

2. CURRENT MEASURES

2.1 LIST OF CURRENT MEASURES

There exists a variety of co-working spaces, provided by both public and private entities. Some spaces can function as co-working spaces despite not being explicitly designed for it.

2.1.a Personal and Community Spaces

Within Homes: HDB allows internal walls to be removed¹⁷ and structural components of flats to be moved to the sides, giving residents a greater degree of flexibility in creating co-working spaces,¹⁸ such as study or work areas, within their homes. URA also has a Home Office Scheme which allows homeowners to operate small offices within their home premises.¹⁹

Void Decks and Community Living Rooms: Newer estates have Community Living Rooms, a common space for residents to socialise and work.²⁰ The Kebun Baru Void Deck is a project providing free Wi-Fi at HDB rental blocks' void decks, to complement a future study corner in the works.²¹ On top of that, there is a prototype for a Smart Void Deck in Jurong East.²²

Community Study Areas: Prior to the Covid-19 pandemic, PA offered community study areas, which were distributed across over 370 community facilities (Community Clubs (CCs), Residents' Committees (RCs) and Residents' Networks (RNs)).²³ They are usually open for as long as the facility is open, and are equipped with public Wi-Fi. Specific examples would be further elaborated in Section 3.3.

Public Libraries: The 25 library branches spread out throughout Singapore form a generally accessible network of spaces for workers. Four public libraries are also equipped with Smart Work Centres (SWCs) to promote the decentralisation of work areas and better work-life

¹⁷ Fiona Lam, "Bigger Homes, Co-Working Spaces in Public Libraries among Ideas for New Urban Normal," The Business Times (The Business Times, June 21, 2021), <https://www.businesstimes.com.sg/real-estate/bigger-homes-co-working-spaces-in-public-libraries-among-ideas-for-new-urban-normal>.

¹⁸ Audrey Tan and Ng Keng Gene, "HDB Considering Offering Open-Plan Flats to Give Home Buyers Flexibility," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, May 30, 2022), <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/housing/hdb-considering-offering-open-plan-flats-to-give-owners-flexibility-desmond-lee>.

¹⁹ "Home Office Scheme," Urban Redevelopment Authority (Urban Redevelopment Authority), accessed January 29, 2023, <https://www.ura.gov.sg/Corporate/Guidelines/Home-Business/Home-Office-Scheme>.

²⁰ "Social Well-Being," Housing & Development Board (Housing & Development Board), accessed January 29, 2023, <https://www.hdb.gov.sg/about-us/hdbs-refreshed-roadmap-designing-for-life/live-well/social-well-being>.

²¹ "Kebun Baru Void Deck Wi-Fi Project," Bridge the Digital Divide (Bridge the Digital Divide), accessed January 29, 2023, <https://www.bridgethedigitaldivide.sg/work-in-progress>.

²² "Smart Void Deck," colours (colours), accessed January 29, 2023, <https://www.col-ours.com/smartvoiddeck>.

²³ "Community Study Areas in CCS, RCS, and RNs for Students," People's Association (People's Association, September 16, 2019), <https://www.pa.gov.sg/newsroom/news/detail/Community-study-areas-in-CCs-RCs-and-RNs-for-students>.

balance.²⁴ They provide amenities such as secured Wi-Fi, working stations, meeting rooms and video-conferencing facilities.²⁵

NGOs and Other Entities: Some NGOs and private companies provide co-working spaces that are free for public access. The Tzu Chi Humanistic Centre offers study spaces for students,²⁶ while the Blossom Youth Centre (closed until further notice) used to offer a study and music room.²⁷ Urban farm Sprout Hub also provides such spaces at their canteen.²⁸

2.1.b Commercial Spaces

Co-Working Space Providers: The rise in demand for hybrid work²⁹ has incentivised firms such as IWG and JustCo to increase the availability of such spaces by about 5% in the near future.³⁰ These spaces are located in the CBD and target corporations by offering a more cost-effective working space for employees. The company SpaceLabs has similar offerings, but is situated in Ang Mo Kio rather than the CBD.³¹

Work Booths: The People's Association and HDB collaborated with workspace provider Switch (by REInvent) to set up work booths in neighbourhood CCs such as at Bukit Timah CC.³² These booths are versatile and can be used for studying, meetings, and even home tuition.

F&B Outlets: Outlets such as cafes, food courts and coffee shops are frequently used as co-working spaces. Generally, business owners expect users to purchase a food item if they would like to work in the space. Cafes are more likely to provide charging points and air-conditioning, while coffee shops are unlikely to provide either.

²⁴ Irene Tham, "New Smart Work Centre to Open in Tampines to Promote Work-Life Balance," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, October 20, 2016), <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/new-smart-work-centre-to-open-in-tampines-to-promote-work-life-balance>.

²⁵ "Smart Urban Planning," Smart Nation Singapore (Smart Nation Singapore), accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.smartnation.gov.sg/initiatives/urban-living/urban-planning>.

²⁶ Alicia Ang, "Five Study Spots to Visit Now That Afterhours Study Is Closed," YOUTHOPIA (YOUTHOPIA, March 8, 2022), <https://youthopia.sg/read/five-study-spots-to-visit-now-that-afterhours-study-is-closed/>.

²⁷ "Blossom Youth Centre (BYC)," Blossom World Society, accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.blossomworld.sg/blossom-youth-centre-byc>.

²⁸ Alicia Ang, "Five Study Spots to Visit Now That Afterhours Study Is Closed," YOUTHOPIA (YOUTHOPIA, March 8, 2022), <https://youthopia.sg/read/five-study-spots-to-visit-now-that-afterhours-study-is-closed/>.

²⁹ Yun Ting Choo, "Demand for Co-Working Spaces Rising as Firms Explore Hybrid Work," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, May 15, 2022), <https://www.straitstimes.com/business/companies-markets/demand-for-co-working-spaces-rising-as-firms-explore-hybrid-work>.

³⁰ Yun Ting Choo, "Commercial Buildings May Have More Co-Working Spaces in Coming Years," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, May 15, 2022), <https://www.straitstimes.com/business/companies-markets/co-working-spaces-could-grow-amid-increased-demand-for-flexi-work>.

³¹ "Spaceship Co-Warehouse Space in Ang Mo Kio," Spaceship, accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.spaceship.com.sg/spacelabs/locations/ang-mo-kio>.

³² Wallace Woon, "Work Booths to Offer 'Work near Home' Solution for Residents in Year-Long Pilot," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, December 16, 2021), <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/community/work-booths-to-offer-work-near-home-solution-for-residents-in-year-long-pilot>.

Shopping Malls and Mixed-Use Facilities: Several shopping malls or integrated facilities around Singapore offer seats and tables, sometimes with charging ports and Wi-Fi, for work. A non-exhaustive list of such facilities include JCube, United Square, Guoco Tower, Downtown East, Funan Mall, Our Tampines Hub and Changi Airport.

2.1.c Other Government Spaces

Work-Near-Home Polycentres: JTC and URA are setting up polycentres such as One-North and the Punggol Digital District - commercial centres outside the CBD that will bring work closer to homes and ease congestion.³³ These polycentres will, beyond conventional office space, also contain co-working spaces.³⁴

Incubators and Niche Spaces: Some incubators or entities in industry niches provide co-working spaces to start-ups in the same industry. Examples that have been cited in Parliament include Innovate 360,³⁵ the Arts Resource Hub,³⁶ the SIMTech Innovation Factory,³⁷ PIXEL,³⁸ the Red Box Singapore³⁹ and A*StartCentral.⁴⁰

Institutes of Higher Learning: IHLs such as ITE Central or NUS generally offer Wi-Fi enabled study spaces open to the public. Some spaces also provide charging ports.

Hospitals: Some of the newer hospitals such as Khoo Teck Puat Hospital and Sengkang General Hospital provide benches and seats in public areas. These spaces do not provide charging points or Wi-Fi access.

Public Service Co-Working Network: As hybrid work arrangements are likely to continue, the Public Service is planning to launch a network of geographically distributed shared

³³ Keng Gene Ng, "Long-Term Plans Will Accommodate Uncertain Future of Trends Such as Work from Home: Ura Chief Planner," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, March 2, 2022), <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/spores-long-term-plans-will-accommodate-uncertain-future-of-trends-such-as-work-from-home-ura-chief-planner>.

³⁴ Taufiq Zalizan, "S'pore in next 50 Years: Open-Plan Flats, 'Identity Corridors', Recreational Spots on Southern Islands among Ura's Plans," TODAY, June 6, 2022, <https://www.todayonline.com/singapore/singapore-next-50-years-ura-1915986>.

³⁵ "About Us - Innovate 360," Innovate 360 - Singapore's Food Accelerator with Facilities, October 19, 2022, <https://innovate360.sg/about/>.

³⁶ "About Arts Resource Hub," National Arts Council, June 21, 2022, <https://www.nac.gov.sg/support/arts-resource-hub/about-arts-resource-hub>.

³⁷ "Simtech Innovation Factory," A* Singapore Institute of Manufacturing Factory (SIMTech Innovation Factory), accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.a-star.edu.sg/simtech/about-IF/overview>.

³⁸ "Imda Pixel Innovation Hub," IMDA PIXEL Innovation Hub (IMDA), accessed January 20, 2023, <https://pixel.imda.gov.sg/#:~:text=PIXEL%20is%20an%20incubation%20and,early%2Dstage%20start%2Dups>.

³⁹ "Book The Red Box Spaces," Youth Corps Singapore, accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.youthcorps.gov.sg/booking>.

⁴⁰ "About A*STARTCENTRAL," ABOUT A*STARTCENTRAL (A*Starcentral), accessed January 20, 2023, [https://www.a-star.edu.sg/enterprise/innovation-platforms/a-startcentral/about-us#:~:text=ABOUT%20A*STAR%20CENTRAL%20\(A*,and%20bolster%20the%20startup%20ecosystem](https://www.a-star.edu.sg/enterprise/innovation-platforms/a-startcentral/about-us#:~:text=ABOUT%20A*STAR%20CENTRAL%20(A*,and%20bolster%20the%20startup%20ecosystem).

co-working spaces located in existing public agency-owned spaces that will be open to all Public Officers. This was announced by Minister Chan Chun Sing in October 2021.⁴¹

2.2 USER CONSIDERATIONS FOR CO-WORKING SPACES

Workers have several considerations in deciding to use a co-working space. Based on interviews with 12 individuals, we have summarised their considerations below. Demographic data of respondents are included in Appendix A.

2.2.a Privacy

Privacy is important as workers may handle sensitive documents. Based on stakeholder interviews, two types of privacy are important - visual and sound. Visual privacy means passersby should not be able to see workers' screens, while sound privacy means passersby should not be hearing a worker discuss sensitive matters. Both are best achieved in an indoor space. However, an outdoor space might still provide visual privacy if a workspace is flushed to a corner, or if the worker takes a sensitive call when passersby are not around.

2.2.b Accessibility

Accessibility refers to how easily the average worker can travel to a co-working space. Accessibility matters to stakeholders, as many commented that the co-working space needed to be within three to 10 minutes of travelling time. While some co-working spaces are available at many locations across the country and are thus accessible to the general population, some are available only in specific areas.

2.2.c Wi-Fi and Charging

With most work done online for those in hybrid work, Wi-Fi needs to be provided, along with charging points for devices. Most stakeholders listed these two points as non-negotiables.

2.2.d Security of Belongings

Beyond the non-negotiables of Wi-Fi and charging, stakeholders specifically wanted co-working spaces to be secure. This is so that belongings could be left unattended for short periods of time for when workers visit the toilet or leave to get food and drinks. Some low-cost methods include providing lockers or installing CCTVs.

2.2.e Capacity Preview

Stakeholders also wanted a way to preview the capacity of a space before heading there, to avoid making a trip down to the space only to find that it is full.

⁴¹ "Written Reply to Parliamentary Question on Alternative Work Venue Arrangements to Support Public Officers Who Do Not Have Suitable Venues at Home for Work-from-Home Arrangements," Parliamentary Replies | Public Service Division, October 5, 2021, <https://www.psd.gov.sg/press-room/parliamentary-replies/written-reply-to-parliamentary-question-on-alternative-work-venue-arrangements-to-support-public-officers-who-do-not-have-suitable-venues-at-home-for-work-from-home-arrangements>.

2.2.f Amenities

This is a catch-all term for other features or ‘perks’ co-working spaces may offer. While Wi-Fi and charging are considered must-haves, other amenities that are good to have include but are not limited to air-conditioning, proximity to a toilet, vending machines, running water, coffee machines and complimentary snacks. Amongst these, the former two amenities were particularly important to stakeholders.

2.2.g Price

Most co-working spaces are paid, while most community spaces that can double up as co-working spaces are free. Based on stakeholder interviews, the price workers and students are willing to pay varies from \$1 to \$5 per hour. However, this is the price they would pay for a space that satisfies the above conditions. For a simpler space containing just tables and chairs, such as in a void deck, stakeholders are unwilling to pay.

2.3 EVALUATION OF CURRENT MEASURES

2.3.a Current Measures Comparison Table

Current Measure	Privacy	Accessibility	Wi-Fi & Charging	Security of Belongings	Capacity Preview	Amenities	Price
Within Homes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Free
Void Decks	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	Free
Community Study Areas	Depends	Yes	Depends	No	No	Depends	Free
Public Libraries	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Free
NGOs and Others	Yes	Yes	Depends	No	No	Depends	Free
Professional Co-working Spaces	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Paid
Work Booths	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Depends	Yes	Paid
F&B Outlets	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	Paid
Shopping Malls	No	No	Depends	No	No	Depends	Free
Polycentres	Depends	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Depends
Incubators	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Paid
Institutes of Higher Learning	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	Free

Current Measure	Privacy	Accessibility	Wi-Fi & Charging	Security of Belongings	Capacity Preview	Amenities	Price
Within Homes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Free
Hospitals	No	No	No	No	No	No	Free
Public Service Network (Public Servants Only)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Depends	Yes	Free
Our Proposal	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Free

2.3.b Evaluation

This table shows that “co-working spaces” is an umbrella term for a diverse group of spaces that vary widely in characteristics and features. This suggests that workers, correspondingly, have a wide range of co-working needs. For some, a simple chair and table will suffice. For others, it is necessary to have a soundproof booth with Wi-Fi and charging. It also shows that homes, and the upcoming public sector co-working spaces, are the only "full-feature" co-working spaces. However, due to reasons cited in Section 1, homes can be uncondusive. Amongst the alternatives, private spaces are within the CBD and come at a cost, while public spaces in libraries and community study areas are free but lower quality and coverage is not as extensive. Though some CCs such as Sengkang CC,⁴² Woodlands Galaxy CC and Woodlands CC⁴³ provide quality coworking spaces, not every CC does. Like public libraries and community study areas, coverage is not extensive.

In short, the range of co-working spaces currently available generally do not match up to homes in terms of privacy, accessibility, cost etc. This encourages workers to WFH. However, some workers unfortunately do not have homes conducive for work; in these cases, it is important to have a conducive alternative. That is what this paper seeks to propose.

⁴² Facebook (Sengkang Community Club, April 24, 2017),

<https://www.facebook.com/SengkangCommunityClub/photos/workspacesengkang-cc-is-now-officially-open-if-you-are-a-working-adult-we-welcom/1507479409286833/>.

⁴³ Facebook (Sayang Sembawang , July 30, 2020),

<https://www.facebook.com/sayangsembawang/posts/study-rooms-now-open-from-10am-to-10pm-at-woodlands-galaxy-cc-level-4-and-woodla/3354637907892579/>.

3. PROBLEM STATEMENT

3.1 OVERVIEW OF SITUATION

The current trend indicates that hybrid work is increasingly popular, both amongst employers and workers. As mentioned, there are also early signs that hybrid work is beneficial for productivity and inclusivity. However, hybrid work can be difficult for some workers due to an uncondusive home environment. These workers will benefit from a variety of alternative, non-home working spaces.

The current measures that provide such non-home working spaces vary significantly and appeal to workers with different needs. However, some of these alternatives are inaccessible for a variety of reasons, such as location and cost. Moreover, there are other related issues, such as an inability to preview the capacity of co-working spaces, which might inhibit uptake.

3.2 PROBLEM STATEMENT

The crux of the issue therefore is that despite an increasing trend towards hybrid work, some workers do not have homes conducive for hybrid work. Simultaneously, some non-home alternatives are also uncondusive or inaccessible. As a result, and as mentioned in Section 1, some workers have neither a conducive home environment nor conducive non-home alternatives. For example, in an IPS study, 27% of respondents cited coping with duo stresses from home and work as their biggest challenge they faced while working from home.⁴⁴

As such, there is room to provide more accessible and conducive non-home co-working spaces for members of the public. Notwithstanding existing government initiatives, this policy proposal seeks to add value by suggesting that existing infrastructure - CCs and void decks - be converted into basic co-working spaces free for members of the public to use.

3.3 DIFFERENCES WITH GOVERNMENT APPROACH

A recent spate of developments have shown that the Government is well-aware of this issue and is moving towards a similar solution. Three specific recent developments indicate so, and our proposal seeks to build on them.

3.3.a Public Service Co-Working Network

This network, covered in Section 2.1.c, is in effect the same as our proposal, in that it provides a widely-accessible network of co-working spaces, accessible to public servants.

⁴⁴ Mathew Mathews et al. (Institute of Policy Studies, Singapore, 2022).

3.3.b Boon Lay Void Deck Study Pods

Nine study pods were launched in three void decks in Boon Lay, in a pilot programme.⁴⁵ If uptake is strong, these study pods will be extended to further housing estates and community spaces. In bringing these spaces to the heartlands, the Government is making co-working spaces more accessible. These pods cost \$4.50 per hour.

3.3.c Marsiling MRT Co-working Space

In line with bringing co-working spaces to the heartlands, where it is more accessible, a new co-working space Staytion has opened in Marsiling MRT station.⁴⁶ This differs from the previous Boon Lay study pods in that it is a space, rather than a pod, and that there are more amenities like a cafe and reading nooks. The space costs \$4.90 per hour.⁴⁷

3.3.d Evaluation

These three recent developments suggest the Government is intent on expanding the number of conducive, non-home co-working spaces available to the public. Moreover, the emergence of these spaces in heartlands, rather than the city centre, indicates that the Government wants to make these spaces more accessible to workers. However, these spaces are priced at around \$4.50 per hour.

In full support of the government's approach of increasing accessibility of co-working spaces, our proposal seeks to build on existing efforts, believing that co-working spaces could be free for workers. This would be achieved by tapping on existing infrastructure in CCs and void decks, enabling co-working spaces to be set up at a relatively low cost so that free provision can be made possible.

⁴⁵ Hong Yi Tay, "Pods Set up in Void Decks to Cater to Requests for Conducive Work, Study Spaces," The Straits Times (The Straits Times, September 12, 2022), <https://www.straitstimes.com/singapore/housing/pods-set-up-in-void-decks-to-cater-to-requests-for-conducive-work-study-spaces>.

⁴⁶ Jia Ying Low, "New Co-Working Space Opening at Marsiling MRT Station, from S\$4.90/Hour," Mothership (Mothership, September 27, 2022), <https://mothership.sg/2022/09/co-working-space-marsiling-mrt-staytion/>.

⁴⁷ Ibid.

4. PROPOSED SOLUTION

4.1 PROVISION OF ACCESSIBLE CO-WORKING SPACES

4.1.a Selected Pathways

Secondary research and our surveys indicate that there is a need for conducive, non-home co-working spaces. However, the expectations different individuals have of co-working spaces vary along a diverse spectrum. While those with non-conducive working spaces at home find a simple co-working space with basic facilities sufficient, those with access to conducive co-working spaces at home expect a more well-furnished co-working space. We have thus segmented the diverse spectrum of needs into two broad categories - basic spaces and well-equipped spaces. We propose two pathways to provide each of these categories. The first pathway is co-working spaces at void decks and the second pathway is co-working spaces at CCs.

4.1.b Rationale for Chosen Pathways

As mentioned, the two pathways cater to two broad segments from within the variegated landscape of co-working needs. They differ in quality and accessibility.

Our first proposed pathway, void decks, are familiar to over 75% of Singaporeans.⁴⁸ Void decks are highly accessible and there are often amenities available within walking distance, such as neighbourhood shopping centres and convenience stores. Our second proposed pathway, CCs, are similarly spread across Singapore, albeit with lower density. The 108 CCs across Singapore each serve an average of 50,000 people.⁴⁹ Thus, while they are still accessible, they are less so than void decks, which are almost literally at one's doorstep.

Beyond the difference in accessibility, the pathways differ in quality. Our proposed void deck co-working spaces will be simple with limited furnishings and facilities. For example, they will not offer air-conditioning or private working booths. In contrast, our proposed CC co-working spaces will be well-equipped.

Void deck spaces, being more basic, would not appeal to individuals with conducive co-working spaces at home. Rather, they are meant to serve the needs of individuals who lack conducive spaces. CC spaces also serve these individuals, but offer spaces of higher quality. If individuals in urgent need of a co-working space find that CCs are full, they can fall back on void decks. If individuals who already have conducive spaces at home find that CCs are full, they might not use void decks, instead falling back on their home space. The two spaces thus efficiently allocate users to co-working spaces, based on the extent of need.

⁴⁸ "Households - Latest Data," Statistics Singapore (Statistics Singapore), accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.singstat.gov.sg/find-data/search-by-theme/households/households/latest-data>.

⁴⁹ "Community Clubs," People's Association (People's Association), accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.pa.gov.sg/our-network/community-clubs>.

Notably, the two pathways are also structured around a quality-accessibility tradeoff to manage costs. Void deck spaces, which are more widespread and accessible, will be more basic. CCs, on the other hand, are scarcer which justify a larger investment per space. Both void decks and CCs are also chosen because they can be retrofitted onto existing infrastructure e.g. installing Wi-Fi routers in a void deck, which is more cost-effective than building infrastructure from scratch.

4.2 OVERVIEW OF TWIN MODALITIES

4.2.a Void Deck Modality

The two pathways primarily address different worker segments with different needs. Void deck spaces cater more to the segment of users who lack conducive co-working spaces at home. Furthermore, while low-income workers are more likely to be in manual jobs that do not allow WFH and have less flexibility than higher-income workers to choose work arrangements, void deck spaces also cater to low-income workers' need for accessible co-working spaces.



Figure 1: St. Georges' Towers HDB Development in Whampoa

Facilities and Description: Void deck spaces are only equipped with basic facilities. This means seats, tables, Wi-Fi, charging points, with varying levels of ventilation and privacy. Figure 1, taken from a recent HDB development, is an example of what such a working space could look like. Apart from a simple configuration of working seats and tables, charging points will be located conveniently for users to charge their devices. Free Wi-Fi will also be provided in the general vicinity of the co-working space. The provision of privacy and

ventilation can be left to HDB's discretion. While offering privacy is difficult in an open space, it might be prudent to provide individual seats and tables rather than shared ones as shown above. In addition, some areas might be naturally well-ventilated, while other spaces might need fans. The void deck might be co-located with neighbourhood facilities such as nearby coffee shops, supermarkets, etc. There will be community activities, frequent footfall, and road traffic around the space. Residents converse or exercise at void decks; on occasion they hold weddings and funerals there. In order to mitigate noise from some of these activities, void deck working spaces might be located in the middle of a cluster of flats.

User Journey: Users take a short walk to the proposed void deck space and begin work. They do not have to pay or book in advance, and can stay for as long as they like. There are no rules on usage e.g. maintaining low noise levels, although users are expected to act considerately. If the user would like a break, they can walk to nearby facilities (if any) to do so. Signs to encourage considerate behaviour may be put up in the area. An example of a situation where one might use this space is if they have an appointment at a shopping centre but is one hour early; they may walk to the nearest void deck to work for a while before their appointment.

Administration: The facilities can be maintained and cleaned by organisations already responsible for maintaining void decks like Town Councils. This will be covered further in Section 4.3. While the void deck may appeal to those with unconducive homes, who can easily access basic spaces without paying for travel, the CC modality may appeal to people willing and able to travel further to access spaces more conducive than their own homes.

4.2.b Community Centre Modality

In contrast to void deck spaces, CC spaces cater more to the segment of users who have conducive co-working spaces at home, but are willing to travel further in exchange for access to a greater variety of support resources and amenities which their homes may not provide. CC spaces are also suitable for the segment of users who lack conducive spaces at home.

Facilities and Description: CCs offers a greater range of amenities within the room due to its built-up structure. Beyond tables, seats, Wi-Fi and charging points, they can offer air-conditioning, better visual and sound privacy, a booking system, food and drinks, access to toilets and security of belongings. Air-conditioning, better privacy, access to toilets and security of belongings are features of the CC spaces that naturally arise out of the existing CC infrastructure. By converting existing rooms within the CC into spaces, it will be situated within four walls and be co-located with CC toilets, vending machines and water coolers. Surveillance facilities within the CC might also give users a greater sense of security.

One facility worth exploring is the ability to preview the space capacity and book seats in advance. It is detrimental if users travel to a space only to find it fully occupied. A booking system can mitigate this. NLB already has a web booking function for their highly-in-demand

seats.⁵⁰ Similarly, ActiveSG has a booking system where users scan QR codes to gain access through gantries. While both would allow walk-ins, they simultaneously give users the chance to preview capacity and book in advance (you cannot preview capacity for NLB). There is also the possibility of providing private, soundproof working pods in CC spaces, although this depends on the availability of funds and physical space. Moreover, additional features such as a simple snack and drink cupboard, where applicable, can be added to the space easily. On this note, it is up to the CC's discretion whether rooms should be permanently converted to co-working spaces, or remain multi-purpose. The CC can stipulate rules at their own discretion e.g. no eating hot food.

As mentioned earlier, void deck spaces might be co-located with nearby facilities like coffee shops and convenience stores. This is even more so for CC spaces, which offers a greater diversity of amenities outside the room but within the CC. For example, at Kampong Chai Chee's CC, there is a NLB branch on the top floor, F&B outlets on the ground floor, and other activities hosted by the CC that users can attend before or after work. CCs are strategically situated within larger economic nodes and offer more supporting resources.

User Journey: Before travelling to the CC, a user might preview the capacity and book a slot to ensure there is space to work. Like void deck spaces, they do not need to pay to do so. They might then walk or take a short commute to the CC. Once there, they sit in their booked space and start working. They need to follow the rules of that space, which are set by the CC. If they are hungry, or need to go to the toilet, they can leave their items in the space and walk outside to a nearby CC toilet, or to nearby F&B outlets.

Administration: Administratively, there already exist systems that can support the functions of the co-working space in the CCs. Since CCs are under the ambit of PA, the current management model for CCs can be applied in maintaining these CC spaces.

The CC modality, with a larger range of features, thus appeals to people who have spaces at home but might want to access spaces more conducive than their homes. The two modalities represent a quality-accessibility tradeoff, each with their own set of pros and cons.

4.3 GOVERNMENT CONSIDERATIONS

Users have different priorities when choosing a space. These user considerations are outlined in Section 2, and influence the set-up of co-working spaces in void decks and CCs. Void decks satisfy the bare minimum facilities needed in a space, based on stakeholder feedback, while CCs offer a wider range and higher quality of facilities. The user considerations in Section 2 thus reflect the demand-side considerations of our proposal. This section outlines considerations we believe the Government may have, although these are not exhaustive.

⁵⁰ Seat booking (National Library Board), accessed January 20, 2023, <https://www.nlb.gov.sg/seatbooking/>.

4.3.a Overarching Models of Co-Working Spaces

In our view, there are two broad approaches in the provision of co-working spaces. The first is to have a hub-and-spoke model of co-working spaces. This involves establishing work centres at a few strategic locations across Singapore, much like URA's model of polycentres.

The second is to have a vast network of smaller pockets of space. This involves establishing a large number of co-working spaces distributed widely across the island, much like the PA's network of community study areas across their 370 facilities. This might also include establishing them in smaller spaces like void decks. Our proposal fits in the second category, setting up many small spaces in favour of several large spaces.

4.3.b Scalability

We believe scalability matters because spaces will be set up throughout the country rather than in a localised zone. Since our proposal taps on established infrastructure networks, we believe it is scalable, with the void deck modality being more scalable.

4.3.c Cost

To create and maintain co-working spaces, the government will have to invest in digital and physical infrastructure to transform existing void deck and community centre spaces into co-working spaces. Beside such initial overhead costs, there are also variable maintenance and management costs. In some instances, the cost may exceed the benefits.

4.3.d Administrating Party

A national model of co-working spaces, which includes both CCs and void decks, cuts across the aegis of organisations such as the PA, HDB, MND and Town Councils. There may need to be an inter-agency group that delegates responsibilities like maintaining a booking system and the different spaces, or gathering feedback.

4.3.e Competing Use of Community Space

Since void decks and CCs are public spaces that are open for various communal uses, there is a need to consider if there will be high opportunity costs in converting these spaces into co-working spaces. This is especially so if the co-working space may become under-utilised and may actually be better suited for other purposes with social benefits.

4.3.f Agglomeration and Social Benefits

With WFH, it is possible for students and workers to feel more socially isolated. Co-working spaces allow for socialising, where users can continue to do their work virtually together in a physical space. In this manner, co-working spaces facilitate bonding amongst users, allowing for increased social cohesion in an increasingly socially distant workplace or school. At the same time, external economies of scale occur when users gather together in the co-working space, where the exchange of ideas and knowledge can take place as well.

4.4 COMPARISON OF TWIN MODALITIES

4.4.a Twin Modalities Comparison Table

User considerations, which have been covered in Chapter 2, are *italicised*, while Government considerations, covered in Section 4.3 above, are **bolded**.

Consideration	Void Deck	CC
<i>Privacy</i>	Minimal physical and audio privacy, although individual seats and tables might be provided	More physical privacy as space is bounded within four walls. No audio privacy within space but CCs at discretion to include private working pods
<i>Accessibility</i>	Highly accessible; available islandwide at void decks; likely to be within walking distance	Less accessible than void decks but still accessible with 108 CCs; island-wide; likely to be within walking distance or a short commute
<i>Wi-Fi & Charging</i>	Available	Available
<i>Security of Belongings</i>	Belongings not secure; cannot be left unattended to go for food or toilet breaks	Belongings relatively secure; can be left unattended for short periods to go for food or toilet breaks; surveillance cameras at CCs
<i>Capacity Preview</i>	No capacity preview or booking system	Capacity preview and booking system might be available at discretion of CC
<i>Amenities</i>	No additional amenities, ventilation might be provided through fans	Additional amenities such as air-conditioning, nearby toilets, vending machines and water coolers available at most CCs; provision of snacks and drinks at discretion of CCs
Overarching Model	Extensive network of hundreds of small spaces can be developed	Moderate network of 108 CCs can be developed

Scalability	Wide diversity in the size and configurations of void decks across Singapore, making it hard to have a standardised physical or aesthetic layout; a flexible model with tables, seats, Wi-Fi and charging can be adopted and scaled across these void decks	CCs may vary even more widely in size, facilities and layout than void decks, making a standardised physical or aesthetic layout even more difficult to implement; guidelines are still possible but model might not be scalable to all 108 CCs
Initial Overhead Cost	Void decks might not be equipped with appropriate tables and seats and unlikely to have pre-existing Wi-Fi and charging points; installing this initial infrastructure from scratch might be costly	CCs likely to have spare tables and chairs, along with pre-existing Wi-Fi and charging points in most rooms; lower initial installation costs as facilities already present
Maintenance Cost	Maintenance cost of basic facilities likely to be modest	Maintenance cost of larger range of facilities likely higher; air-conditioning and booking system impose additional running costs
Administrating Party	Administrative responsibility may fall under HDB or Town Councils; administrative load likely relatively small	Administrative responsibility may fall under individual CCs or the PA; administrative load likely slightly larger
Competing Use of Community Space	Void decks used by residents to socialise or play sports and are occasionally booked for weddings, funerals and other functions; competition for usage of space moderate	CCs are hubs of community activity, with many competing uses of space; permanent conversion of rooms to co-working spaces might come at high opportunity cost
Agglomeration and Social Benefits	Pattern of usage likely more touch-and-go; environment less conducive for exchange of ideas and social interaction, but still favourable to working in isolation at home	Pattern of usage likely over a longer period; environment more conducive for exchange of ideas and social interaction and favourable to working in isolation at home

4.4.b Evaluation

The comparison table suggests that the void deck spaces and CC spaces do broadly fall along an accessibility-quality or cost-quality tradeoff. Void deck spaces lack facilities but are easier and less costly to administer. CC spaces are more costly and complicated, but also offer better agglomeration benefits and facilities. Both modalities complement each other: the void deck modality offers a larger volume of highly accessible spaces while the CC modality offers quality co-working spaces.

4.5 MODALITY-SPECIFIC CONSIDERATIONS

4.5.a Void Deck - Noise Levels

Void deck spaces are particularly exposed to external distractions such as children playing sports or noise pollution from traffic. In some void decks, footfall might be so high that a co-working space is simply uncondusive.

4.5.b Void Deck - Non-Work Users

Void decks are free for all to use, including people who do not need to work. The availability of Wi-Fi and charging ports might attract users looking to simply charge their devices rather than work, which reduces the availability of space for users who want to work.

4.5.c CCs - Overcompetition and Equality of Access

Given the wide range of facilities available at proposed CC spaces, there is likely to be high competition for these spaces. Users might exploit online booking systems by, for example, waiting till midnight to book spaces. Competition for spaces might also disadvantage those who cannot book spaces early. Working parents, for example, might need to send children to school in the morning, leaving them unable to secure a place early in the morning.

4.6 MITIGATING COSTS

Though we believe the co-working spaces should be kept free, there are many significant and mitigating cost considerations not contemplated in this paper. Thus, should the relevant ministries or agencies find it necessary to impose costs on users, as is currently the model, elements of accessibility and affordability may be introduced in the following ways:

4.6.a Complementary Credits

Like the \$100 ActiveSG credits given for signing up for the ActiveSG movement, Singaporeans and Permanent Residents may be given credits to entice users to try the facilities, following which the relevant ministries or agencies can charge fees as demanded by budgetary reasons. However, this would not apply to void decks due to the non-exclusionary nature of the space, and not all recipients of the credits will be able to make use of the credits.

4.6.b Income-based Subsidies

Targeted subsidies can help lower-income students and workers who are least able to pay for current facilities. This approach was taken by the aforementioned Boon Lay Void Deck Study Pods (Section 3.3.b) which provided 25 lower-income students 35 hours of free credit worth over \$150.

4.6.c Needs-based Subsidies

Similarly, a needs-based approach based on demographic might be adopted. Students generally do not earn income and thus are less able to afford paid co-working spaces. Subsidies might be given to users who are students under a certain age.

5. FURTHER EXPANSION

Below are several additional suggestions for expanding the network of co-working spaces.

5.1 DEVELOPING A CO-WORKING ECOSYSTEM

As discussed previously, users would benefit from a clear and easy booking system that conveys availability of rooms prior to booking. Future enhancements may include a geographic map of Singapore that pins the locations of all co-working locations and their live capacities. This is already being done with ActiveSG gyms, demonstrating that technologies that reduce friction and can thereby increase uptake have already been implemented. A phone application could also enhance the end-user experience.

5.2 EXPANSION TO RCs AND RNs

RCs and RNs may be an interesting and promising intermediary between the void deck and CC pathways. Specifically located close to housing estates but contained in a discrete built environment, RCs and RNs may enjoy the benefit of proximity that void deck spaces provide while simultaneously, as an enclosed room, being a platform that allows for greater amenities and quality of co-working space like CCs.

5.3 TARGETED RESOURCE ALLOCATION

Constituencies with younger populations and by proxy more users are likely to benefit more from a higher density of co-working spaces. Similarly, to prevent infrastructure duplication, areas with more existing spaces like libraries might not need as many new spaces.

5.4 FEEDBACK GATHERING MECHANISMS

This paper relies on a key assumption that younger constituencies have a greater need for co-working spaces than mature constituencies. However, many potentially unknown considerations also affect demand for co-working spaces. Gathering feedback will help capture some of these considerations and optimise the provision of spaces.

5.5 COORDINATING PUBLIC COMMUNICATIONS

As CCs and void decks vary widely in size and facilities, the public should be aware that some variation in quantity and quality is natural. A coordinated, nationwide roll-out of these void deck and CC spaces can also be considered.

6. CONCLUSION

The uptake of hybrid working arrangements — and positive reception to it — has given rise to a greater demand for conducive co-working spaces, whether at home or in public areas. At the same time, there are insufficient conducive non-home alternatives, which is particularly important for workers who lack conducive spaces at home.

As such, we are proposing establishing a network of co-working spaces free of charge to users, which will be set up in two modalities: void deck spaces and CC spaces. Void deck spaces are more accessible and cost-effective to set up but less well-equipped; CC spaces are slightly less accessible and less cost-effective, but more well-equipped. The two modalities complement each other, catering to different user segments. The general approach is to take advantage of existing infrastructure to set up a network of spaces.

Recent moves by the Government show that they have already begun moving in the direction of expanding the availability of conducive, non-home co-working spaces. However, the Government's approach thus far requires these spaces to be paid for. We believe that offering them for free instead, albeit more costly, is a worthwhile investment, and have structured the proposal to be cost-effective in some aspects.

We believe that our proposal goes a small step further in setting Singapore up for the continual and inevitable uptake of hybrid work arrangements.

7. APPENDIX

APPENDIX A - DEMOGRAPHIC DATA OF INTERVIEW RESPONDENTS

Age	Occupation
52	Church Ministry Support Staff
24	Final Year University Student / Data Engineer
22	University Student
17	Junior College 1 Student
27	Finance Analyst
15	Secondary 3 Student
21	University Student
18	University Student
46	Service Manager in Semiconductor Industry
18	Polytechnic Student
27	Human Resource Manager in Tourism Sector
21	Transport Operator (NSF)

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